

Today we have no Temple service, so instead we pray. With our prayers we attempt to replicate, in spiritual terms, the Holy Temple service, and hopefully thus to elicit the same result, the same atonement, which was effected by the Temple service of yore.

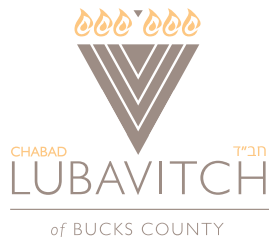
Every Jewish person is a potential temple for G-d, and every individual is the serving high priest in his or her personal temple. The goal of the Yom Kippur prayer service is to access the Holy of Holies of this temple.

The Holy of Holies housed the golden Ark which contained the holy Tablets. The Tablets were unique in that the Ten Commandments were etched into them, unlike a Torah Scroll whose words are penned on its surface. G-d's word was part of its very fabric, not an added component which was appended to its being. To erase the words would be to destroy the Tablets themselves.

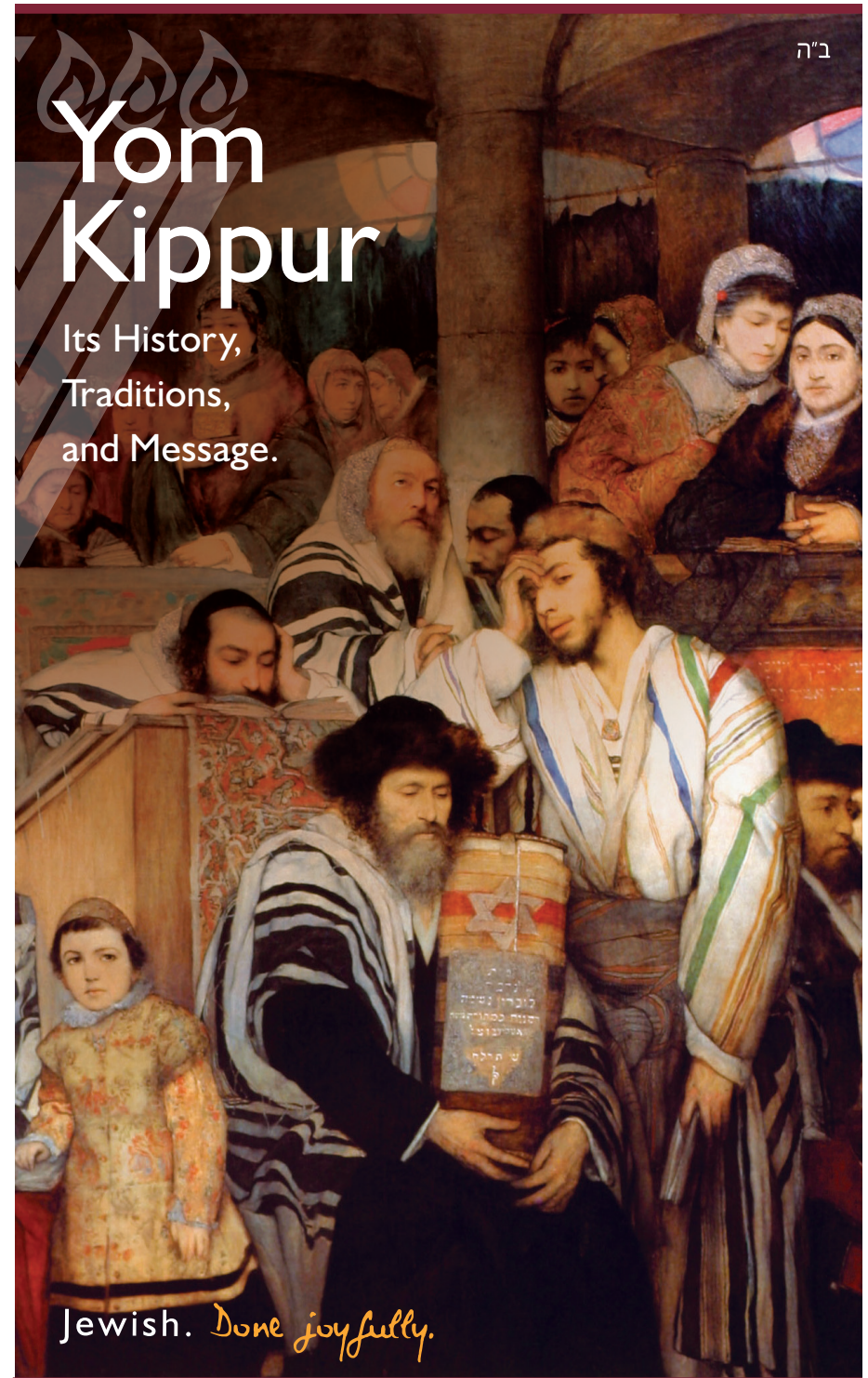
Throughout the year we serve G-d with our "external," conscious, faculties. We connect with Him with our minds, by attempting to comprehend Him and His messages. We work on creating a warm and emotional relationship with Him through contemplating on His greatness and His kindness towards us. But the human mind and heart are fickle at best -- they are add-on software, not the soul itself -- and the relationship that results from their efforts is, therefore, akin to ink on parchment, subject to fading and even erasure.

The innermost "chamber" of the Jewish soul, however, its Holy of Holies essence, shares a Tablet-like connection with G-d. At our core we are connected to G-d not by virtue of any effort, nor does the relationship require cultivation -- it is who we are, "a veritable part of G-d Himself."

And on Yom Kippur we have the ability to access this normally sub-conscious chamber. In doing so, we refresh our relationship for the year to come, and we also have a reciprocal effect on G-d. He is reminded that His relationship with us is also part and parcel of who He is. He can no more forsake us than we can forsake Him. And as such, no matter the transgressions of the past year, G-d grants His children atonement and seals them in the Books of Life and Prosperity.



For more info log onto to
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Yom Kippur

Its History,
Traditions,
and Message.

Jewish. Done joyfully.

What is Yom Kippur

Yom Kippur commemorates the day that G-d forgave the Jewish people for the sin of the Golden Calf. Forty days after hearing G-d say at Mount Sinai: "You shall not have the gods of others in My presence; you shall not make for yourself a graven image," the Jews committed the cardinal sin of idolatry. Moses spent nearly three months on top of the mountain pleading with G-d for forgiveness, and on the tenth of Tishrei it was finally granted: "I have pardoned, as you have requested."

From that moment on, this date, henceforth known as the Day of Atonement, is annually observed as a commemoration of our special relationship with G-d, a relationship that is strong enough to survive any rocky bumps it might encounter. This is a day when we connect with the very essence of our being, which remains connected to G-d regardless of our outward behavior.

And while it is the most solemn day of the year, we are also joyful, confident that G-d will forgive our sins and seal our verdict for a year of life, health, and happiness.

Yom Kippur Laws and Traditions

PREPARATIONS

On the day before Yom Kippur, the primary mitzvah is to eat and drink in abundance. Two festive meals are eaten, one earlier in the day, and one just prior to the onset of Yom Kippur. Some of the day's other observances include requesting and receiving honey cake, in acknowledgement that we are all recipients in G-d's world and in prayerful hope for a sweet year; begging forgiveness from anyone whom we may have wronged during the past year; giving extra charity; and the ceremonial blessing of the children.

LIGHT THE CANDLES

Before sunset, women and girls light holiday candles, and everyone makes their way to the synagogue for the Kol Nidrei services.

SPIRITUAL RE-FOCUS

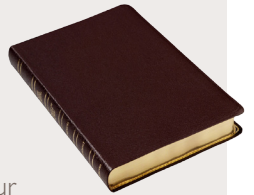
On Yom Kippur, we are likened to the angels, who have no physical needs. Therefore, instead of focusing on the physical, we spend much of our day in



the synagogue, engaged in repentance and prayer. We abstain from food and drink, do not wash or anoint our bodies, do not wear leather footwear, and abstain from spousal intimacy.

PRAYER SERVICES

In the course of Yom Kippur we will hold five prayer services: 1) Maariv, with its solemn Kol Nidrei service, on the eve of Yom Kippur; 2) Shacharit—the morning prayer; 3) Musaf, which includes a detailed account of the Yom Kippur Temple service; 4) Minchah, which includes the reading of the Book of Jonah.



Finally, in the waning hours of the day, we reach the climax of the day: the fifth prayer, the Neilah ("locking") prayer. The gates of Heaven, which were open all day, will now be closed—with us on the inside. During this prayer we have the ability to access the most essential level of our soul. The Holy Ark remains open throughout. The closing Neilah service climaxes in the resounding cries of "Hear O Israel... G-d is one." Then joy erupts in song and dance (a Chabad custom is to sing the lively "Napoleon's March"), followed by a single blast of the *shofar*, and the proclamation, "Next year in Jerusalem."

FESTIVE BREAK-FAST

After the fast we partake of a festive after-fast meal, making the evening after Yom Kippur a Yom Tov (festival) in its own right.

INSIGHTS FROM THE REBBE

How to Enter the Holy of Holies

On Chanukah we light the menorah and on Passover we eat matzah. But what is Yom Kippur all about? Well, though there are a lot of don'ts associated with the holiest day of the year -- eating, drinking, leather footwear, bathing, etc. -- Yom Kippur is most associated with praying, long prayer services that occupy most of the hours of the holiday.

Interestingly, prayer is barely mentioned in the Biblical instructions for Yom Kippur. Instead, the Torah devotes an entire chapter to the procedure of the Holy Temple service on Yom Kippur, a service that was unmatched on any other holiday in terms of length, arduousness and detail. The highlight of the Yom Kippur Temple service was the convergence of the holiest elements of time, space, and life form. On the holiest day of the year, the holiest person -- the High Priest -- entered the holiest place on earth, the Holy of Holy chamber in the Temple sanctuary, where he would pray on behalf of all his Jewish brethren and secure their atonement.